The diagnosis caused Soonoo much anxiety. The doctors too were not very hopeful that the treatment would significantly improve her condition. The three siblings remained at their mother's side, spending with her virtually all her waking hours. Ratan's presence gave her great solace and comfort. The mother–son relationship was so intense that the two sisters left them alone when Soonoo was particularly crestfallen and feeling despondent. Shireen recalls how Soonoo broke down a day before her surgery. Seeing how downcast their mother was, the sisters tiptoed out of the room, knowing very well that if there was anyone who could lift her sagging spirits, it was Ratan. Shireen adds that 'he gave her lots of strength', more than they could give her. In such situations, there was virtually no space for any other.

An Incomparable Loss

Throughout his three-odd months' stay in the US, Ratan was also burdened by the compulsive urge to complete the Strategic Plan. His new responsibility as chairman, TIL, weighed heavily on him. Whenever he could snatch some time, he worked on the plan. And he did so mostly when his mother was asleep. As he recalled to an interviewer, 'I found myself sitting in the visitors' lounge for four months in Sloan Kettering', writing the Strategic Plan for the group.

By August, Soonoo's condition started improving. Happy with the development, Ratan returned to India, from where he monitored her treatment very closely. The plan was to bring her back to India for convalescence. But unfortunately, her health suddenly took a turn for the worse. Despite the best medical treatment and the loving care of her children, the end came relatively soon. About four months after the doctors concluded that she had lung cancer, Soonoo was no more. She breathed her last on 7 October 1982 in the US, five months short of her sixty-fourth birthday.

Ratan, Shireen and Deanna were shattered. Messages of condolence poured in from all corners of the world, but they were of little consolation. They were alone in their moment of grief. They decided to cremate their mother in the US and bring the ashes back to India. As Ratan recalls, the 'logistics' of getting a body back to India was daunting. Shireen was against bringing the body back too, as the casket would have been put in the